Jail in Trivandrum, before being caught and brought here. Ripper, during my stay in Viyyur prison became friendly, even sympathetic to me.

The cells were about 7 ft wide and 10 ft long, with the toilet in the far right corner as you entered it. The gate of each cell had eight wrought iron bars. I was given cell number six. My neighbours were S K Sharma in cell number five and Sasikumar on cell number seven. Chandrasekhar was given cell eight, something he bitterly complained about since his numerologist-astrologer had told him that eight is an unlucky number for him.

'Something bad is going to happen to me,' Chandrasekhar told me the next morning when we were let out of the cell for a bath in the open.

I have been a believer in God throughout my life, but never bothered about such numerological nonsense. Moreover, when you are falsely implicated in a case and are trying to find ways to prove your innocence, the number of your cell is the least significant of concerns. I wanted to ask him what worse can happen to him, and me, than what we were going through. I stopped myself and said, with my tongue firmly in cheek, 'I too think so. You may be hanged.'

We were allowed to step out only when all the other prisoners were locked in their cells. There was an open space where we could take bath from a few cement tanks filled with water. Slowly resuming small talk with Sasi, I would pull Chandra's leg occasionally reminding him of his ominous cell number eight.

I told Sasi about the number of bars on the gates; that I had been playing mathematical games with the bars during free time. Number eight, like any number for that matter, has some specialties. It is the first number which is neither prime nor semi-prime. It is the first number of the form p^3, p being an integer greater than 1. It is the base of the octal number system used in computers, it is also the number of vertices a cube has. For Chandra, however, it was just a bad number.

One day out on the verandah with Sasi, Chandra and Sharma, I said, 'By the way, Chandra,' did you count the number of bars on the cell gate?'

'No, why?' Chandra was all curious.